

SURVEY ANALYSIS + PUBLIC TRANSIT

NYC Transit Rider Experience

Spring 2026 Insights

Analysis of the MTA's biannual Customers Count rider satisfaction survey — subway, bus, and paratransit performance across NYC's five boroughs.

92,000+

SUBWAY RIDERS SURVEYED

5

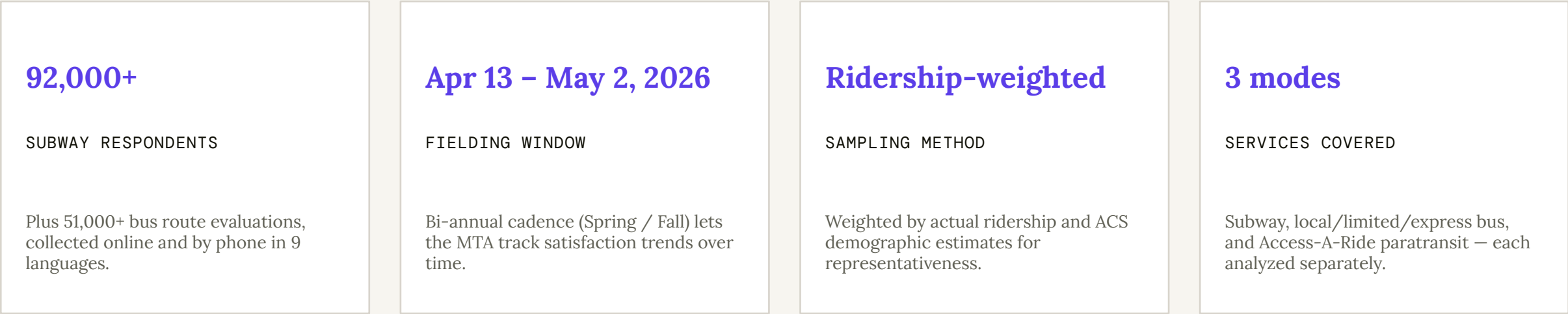
NYC BOROUGHES

63%

OVERALL SATISFACTION

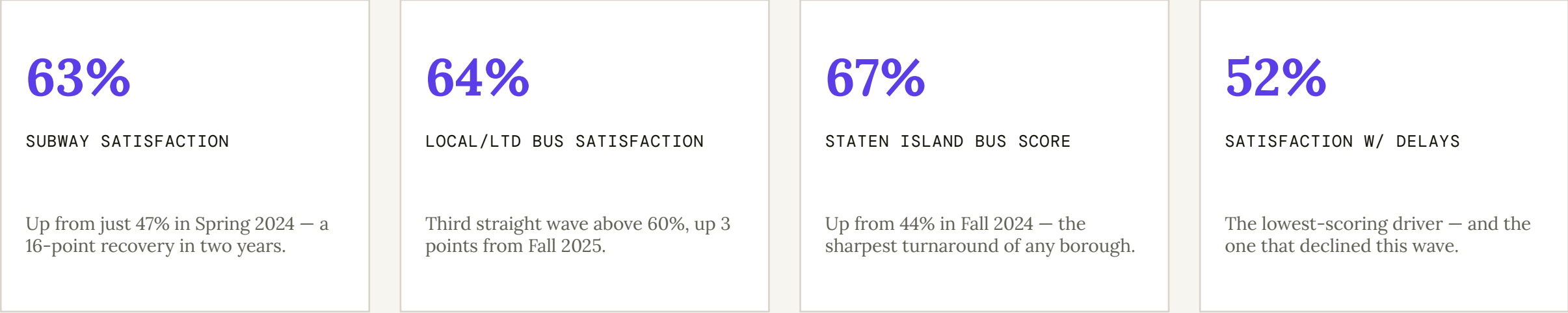
Why the MTA tracks rider satisfaction every season

The Metropolitan Transportation Authority (MTA) runs the “Customers Count” survey twice a year across subway, bus, and Access-A-Ride (AAR) paratransit services — one of the largest recurring transit satisfaction studies in the U.S.



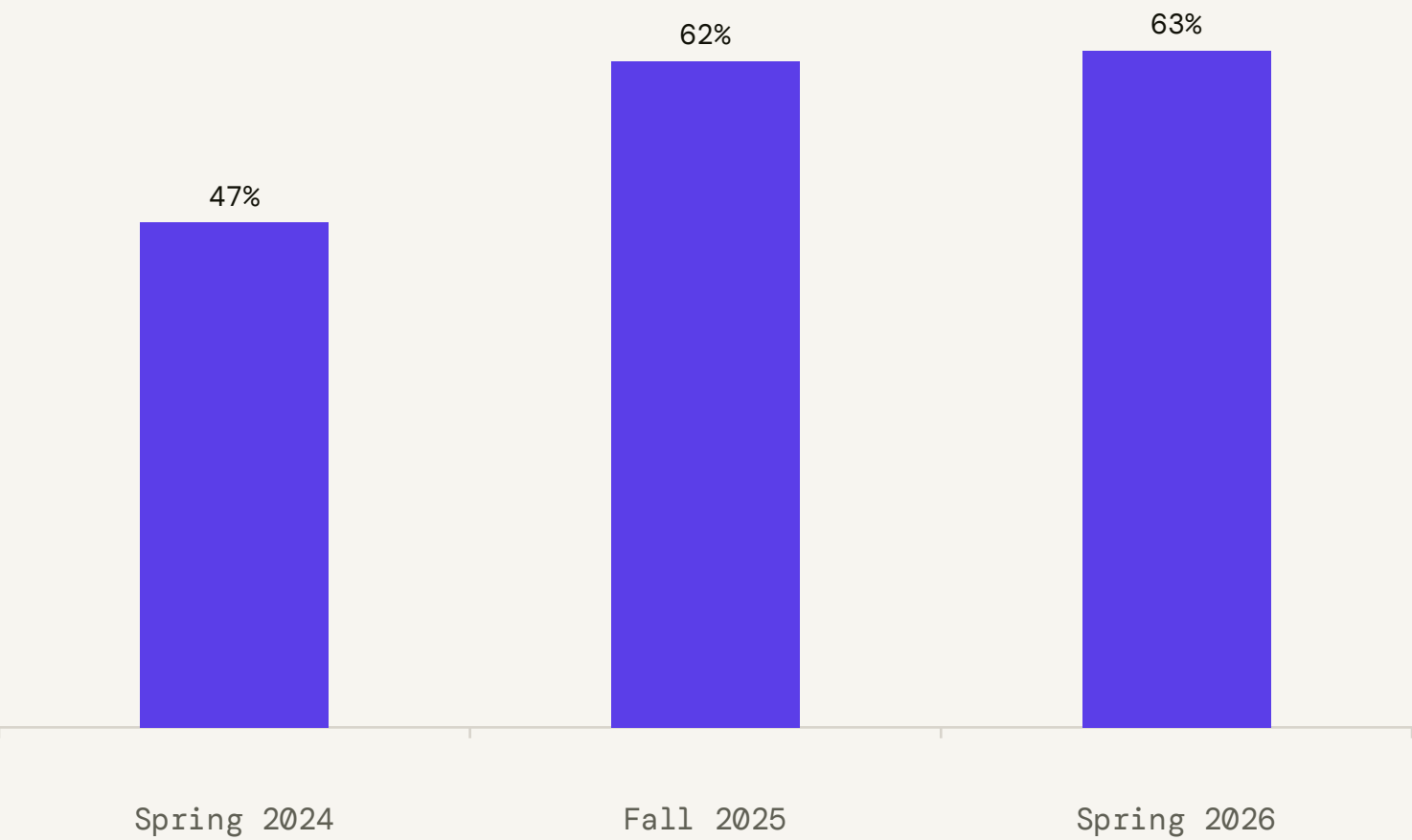
What this analysis covers: the Spring 2026 wave's published results — satisfaction trends, key drivers, borough differences, and recent service-change impacts — to identify where NYC transit is improving and where it still has ground to make up.

Satisfaction is climbing — but unevenly across modes and boroughs



Bottom line: the system-wide recovery story is real, driven especially by bus service in Staten Island and Queens. The remaining gap is concentrated in a few specific drivers — delay frequency and onboard cleanliness — rather than being spread evenly across the system.

Subway satisfaction has recovered sharply since 2024



WHY IT MATTERS

A 16-point jump in two years is a rare pace of improvement for a transit system this size — and it's held steady rather than reversing.

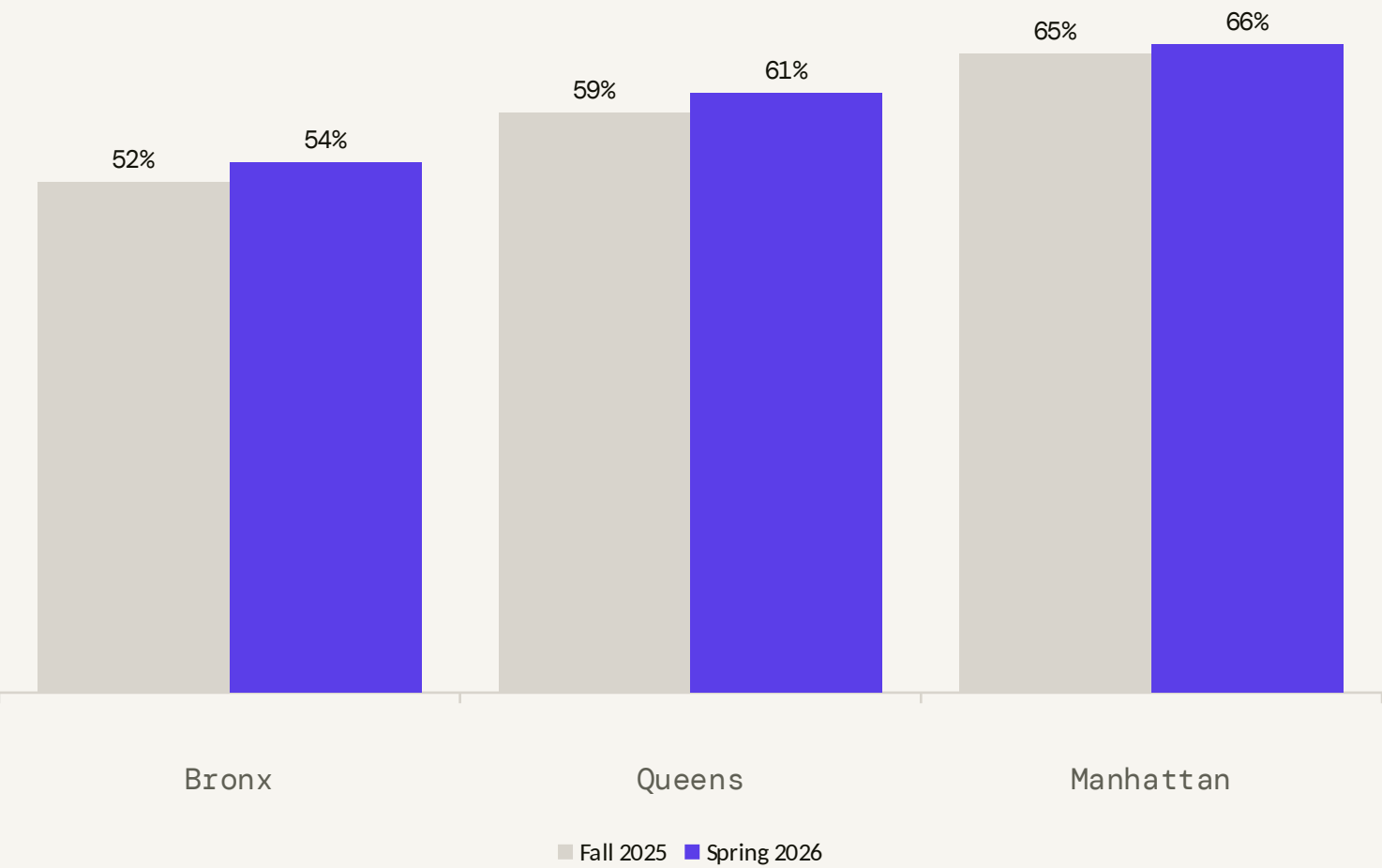
Service reliability, safety, and cleanliness remain the top 3 drivers of this score — unchanged wave over wave, which suggests the recovery is broad-based rather than a one-off.

Delay frequency is the weakest link in the subway experience



Insight: Satisfaction with delay frequency (52%) sits meaningfully below every other driver — and declined a point this wave, the only key driver to move backward. Cleanliness on board also slipped slightly, likely tied to winter ridership patterns.

Every reported borough improved — Manhattan leads, Bronx lags

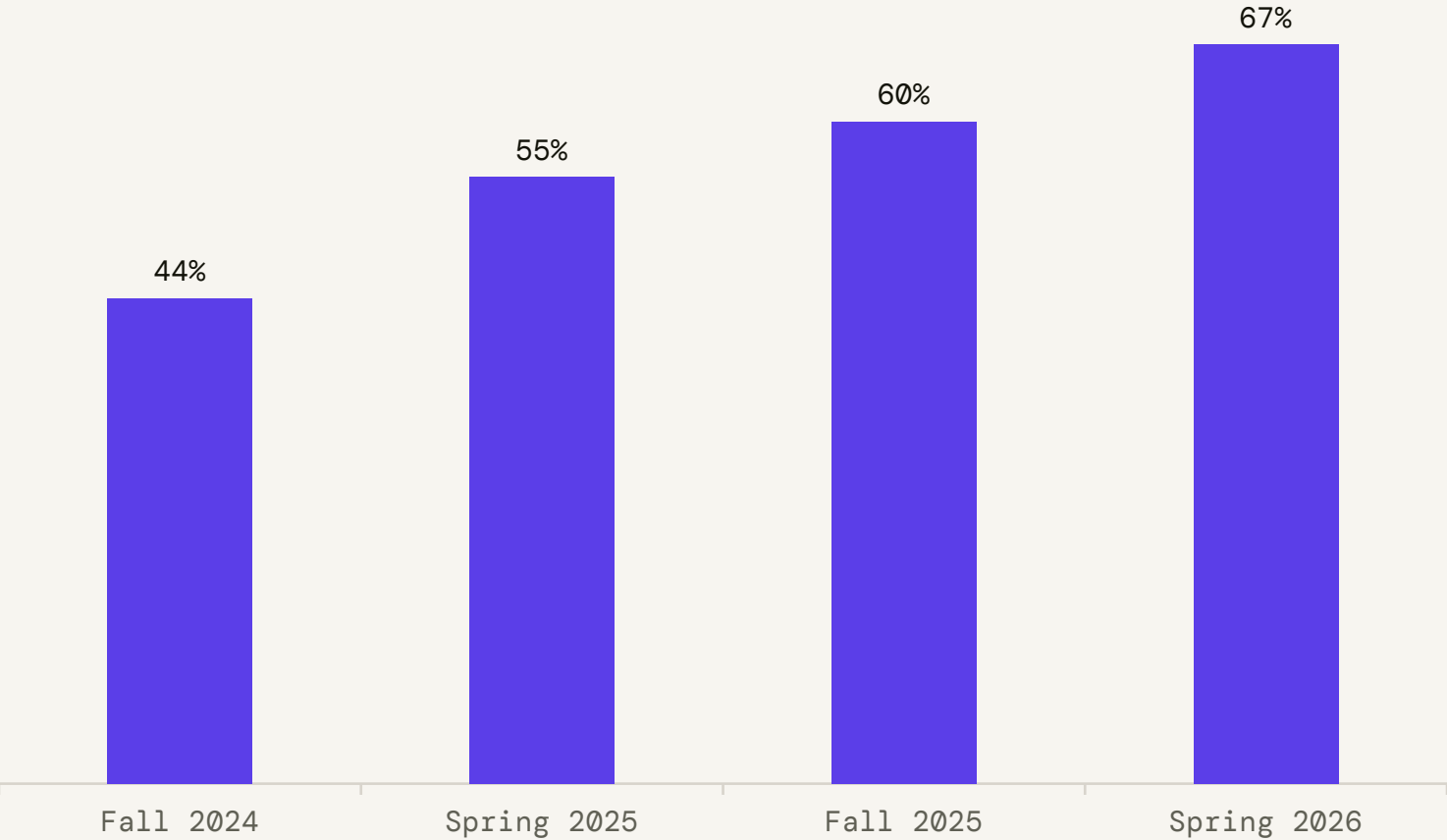


WHY IT MATTERS

Manhattan riders remain the most satisfied at 66%, but the Bronx — while improving — still trails by 12 points at 54%.

The gap is narrowing every wave, not widening — a sign that system-wide improvements are reaching every borough, just at different speeds.

Staten Island bus satisfaction rose 23 points in 18 months

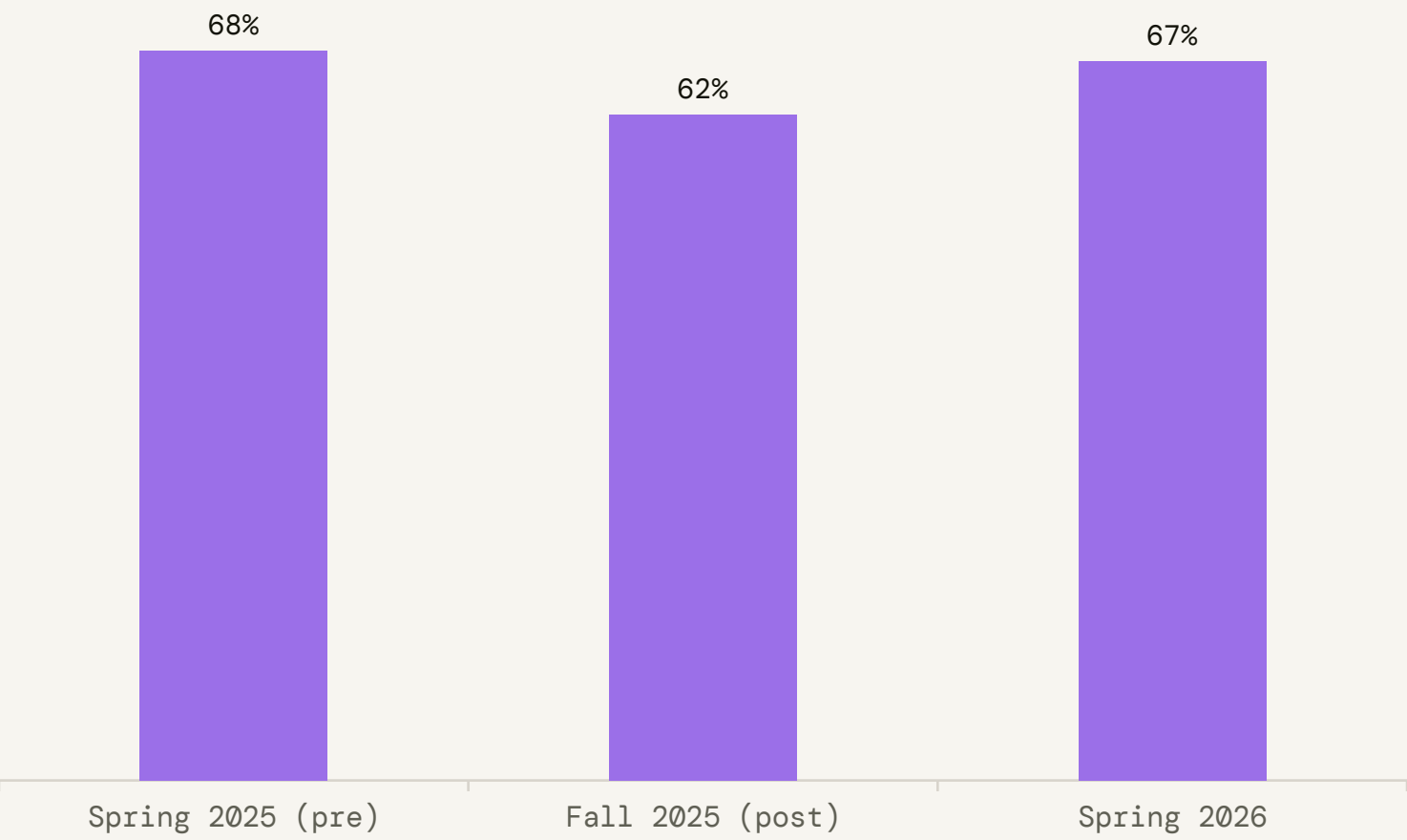


STRONGEST TURNAROUND

Overall bus satisfaction rose 23 points – the single largest improvement of any borough or mode in this dataset.

Service reliability (+21 pts) and waiting times (+20 pts) drove most of the gain – a clear signal that added service frequency, not marketing, moved the number.

Queens bus satisfaction dipped post-redesign, then recovered

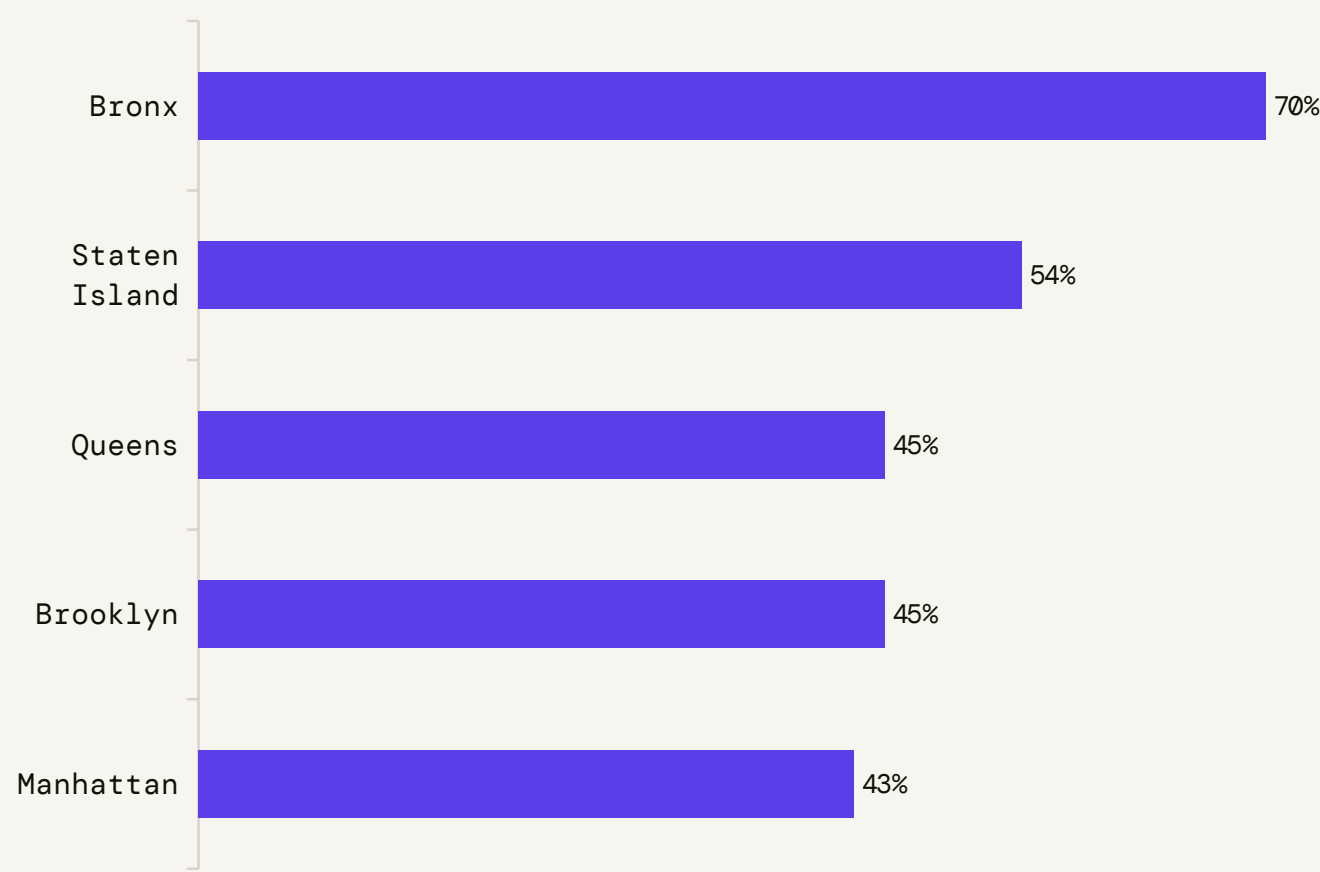


A TEMPORARY DIP

Major route redesigns predictably cause short-term disruption — satisfaction fell 6 points right after rollout, then recovered nearly all the way back within two waves.

This is a useful benchmark: expect a dip after any major service change, and budget 2–3 survey waves for riders to adjust before judging the redesign's success.

Safety enforcement is visible — and unevenly distributed



ACCESS-A-RIDE HOLDS STEADY

AAR satisfaction is 72% (May 2026) and has stayed above 70% most months even as ridership surpassed 1 million trips per month for the first time.

Bronx riders report seeing fare enforcement (70%) far more than any other borough — worth checking whether that reflects enforcement intensity or just rider visibility/perception.

Five moves, ranked by expected rider impact

1

Target delay frequency directly

It's the lowest-scoring and only declining key driver. Root-cause it by line before investing further in other attributes.

2

Replicate the Staten Island bus playbook

Whatever drove the 23-point turnaround (frequency, reliability) is the strongest signal in this dataset — document it and test it in the Bronx.

3

Set a 2-3 wave recovery expectation for redesigns

The Queens dip-then-recovery pattern should become the default forecast shared with riders before future redesigns launch.

4

Investigate onboard cleanliness seasonality

The winter dip in cleanliness satisfaction recurs wave over wave — a seasonal cleaning/staffing plan could smooth it out.

5

Watch AAR capacity as ridership grows

Satisfaction is holding at 72% through record demand, but continued growth past 1M trips/month deserves a capacity check before it slips.

SOURCE & METHODOLOGY

Built entirely on public MTA data.

Every figure in this deck comes from the MTA's publicly released Spring 2026 Customers Count survey report — no proprietary or client data involved.

mta.info/document/215041